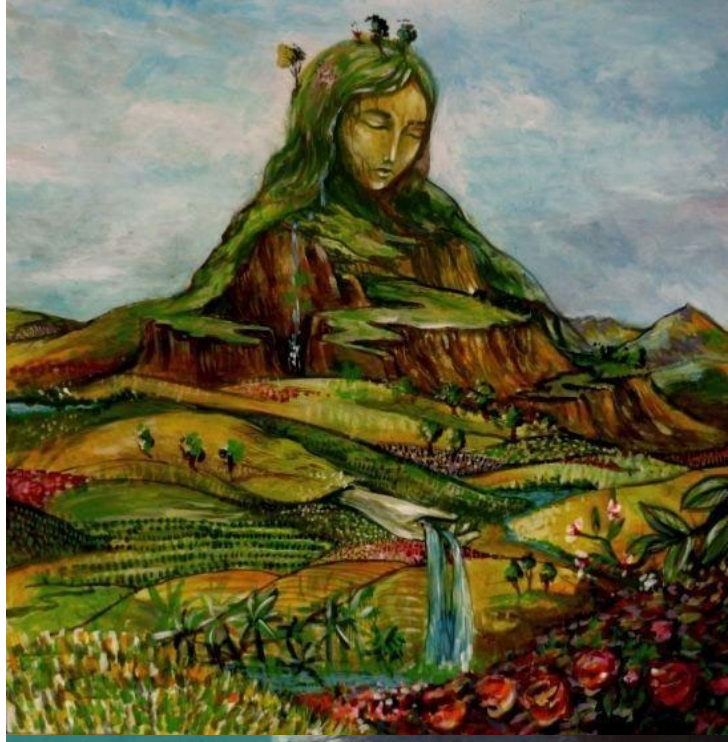
Life-making in the Anthropocene: care, reproduction, imagination

Living in the Anthropocene

19 October 2026

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Github repository for slides

Plan for today

- Picking up the care thread
  - ‘Why do ~~people~~ WE act in contradictory ways?’

  Joan Tronto: *Homines curans* vs *homo oeconomicus*
  - *Care as a cycle: caring about, caring for, caregiving, care-receiving, caring with*
  - Care as ethic, a practice, a democratic ideal
- Today: care as *labour*, the work that reproduces life

“Life-making increasingly conflicts with the imperatives of profit-making” (Bhattacharya, in Barca 2020: 7)







Life-making includes also resistance, practice and imagination

→ Whose stories, whose futures?

Welcome to the Anthropocene! (2012)

Discuss with your neighbour (5-7mins)

- Who is We, and who is the hero?
- Whose work keeps the world going, and whose is missing?
- What shape does the story have?



https://vimeo.com/39048998

A master narrative?

- The official storyline continues the growth story, with industrial modernity as hero, science and technology as engine
- (Eco-)capitalist realism: easier to imagine the end of the world than the end of growth

→a “safe operating space” for business as usual?

Stefania Barca: *Forces of reproduction* as those who keep the world alive, e.g. subsistence farmers, carers, teachers, nurses, waste pickers… (discuss – what happens when we conflate social groups?)

- Reproductive labour drawn into the circuit of value until worker and environment are exhausted
  - Gendered dimensions
- Unequal exchange drains the conditions of life-making from South to North



Climate coloniality

COP26, offsetting/fossil fuel lobbying, but also resistance and alternatives

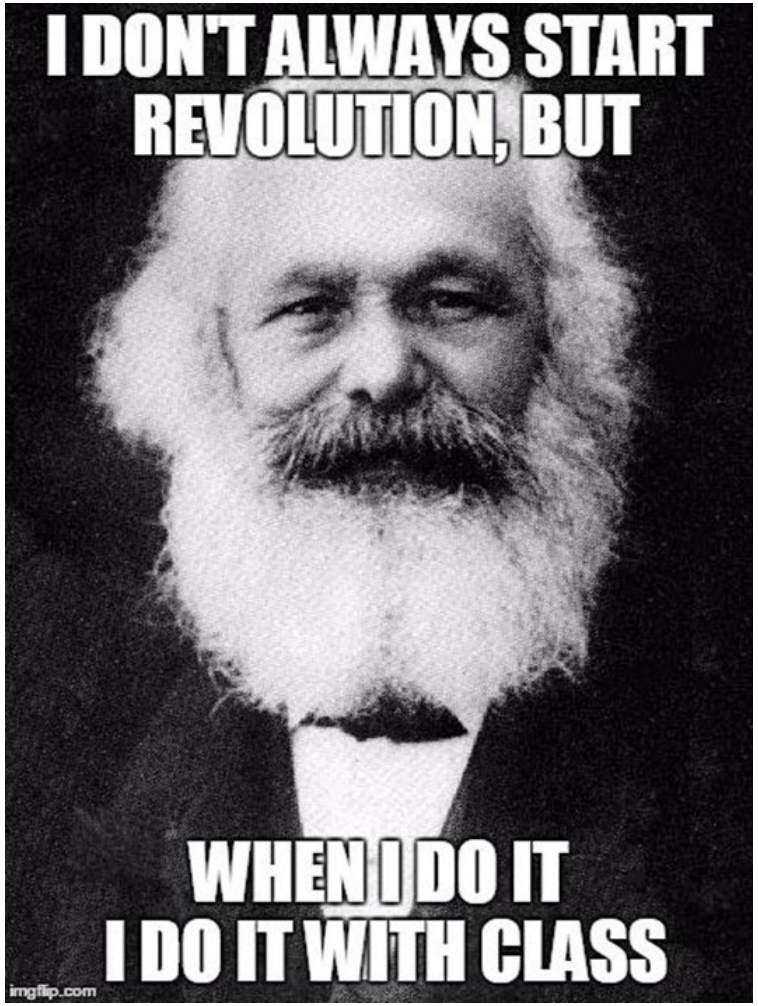
→ Climate and ecological emergency continues colonial power relations, harms colonised, racialised people made vulnerable and disposable

- *Material:* unequal exchange, carbon offsets and REDD+, land and water grabs, rare-earth mining, debt, emissions offshored to the South
- *Power and injustice:* who pays, who is expendable, who is spared for now
- *Epistemic:* climate knowledge dominated by Northern, white, male experts; apocalypse stories describe a white future while for many it is past and present

Resilience as demanded labour: absorb the disaster, rebuild (→exhaustion)

- Which methods can we use (in our science and beyond)?
- Whose climate grief gets named? (back to Niklas….)

Break


I DON'T ALWAYS START REVOLUTION, BUT
WHEN I DO IT I DO IT WITH CLASS
imgflip.com

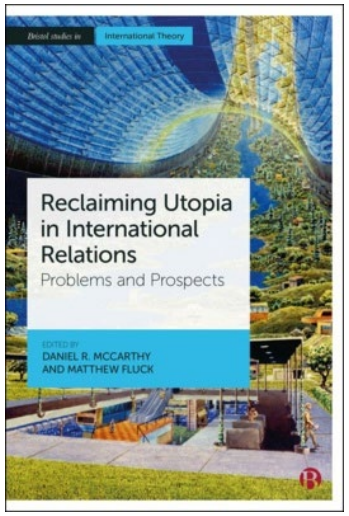
Life stories of the Anthropocene

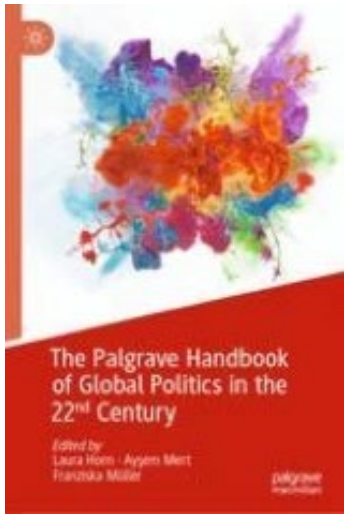
- The Hero's rules: a story flies like an arrow from here to there; conflict is its centre; it's no good without him
- Le Guin: a story as a bag or medicine bundle, holding things in relation. Conflict is one element among many; the point is ongoing process



Group Exercise: **Tell the Anthropocene as a carrier-bag story** (10mins)
Who is in the bag? Name at least three people, creatures or things whose work kept the world alive while the line went up.
What do they carry?
What holds the bag together?
Where is conflict? It stays in the story… as one element among others.
How does it end? Or does it?

Do we (still) need utopia in the Anthropocene?





- Older utopias assumed endless growth and mastery over nature - the Anthropocene breaks the stable conditions that long-term planning relied on
- Indigenous and colonised communities already live in their ancestors' dystopian futures (→ Sultana)
- So past, present and future have to be thought together, against linear progress (Le Guin ftw)
- *The question of meaningful agency results often in climate grief/anxiety,* solastalgia, paralysis (back to Niklas…)
  - *Perspectives: Living in the ruins; Pluriversal agency (e.g.* buen vivir, eco-swaraj, ubuntu, Zapatista autonomy…)

Make your own Anthropocene meme

- Go to https://imgflip.com/memegenerator/Always-Has-Been or https://www.kapwing.com/studio/editor/templates
- Insert a line for the surprised astronaut. *Keep* the Always has Been
- OR use any other meme template – it's up to you!
- Upload to the github in today's session



Mid-term evaluation

- What have you enjoyed so far about the course?
- What has been challenging and what could be improved?

- Which suggestions, ideas, comments, critique do you want to bring to the Learning and Teaching in the Anthropocene workshop on 9 November?